

Floetry's Tiny Desk Concert Is a Joyful, Soulful Reunion a Decade in the Making

From: NPR Music Mined: 2026-06-02 5 min read

There's something electric about a reunion that feels less like a comeback and more like a homecoming. For Floetry the British R&B duo of Natalie "The Floacist" Stewart and Marsha "The Songstress" Ambrosius their Tiny Desk concert was exactly that: a warm, playful, and utterly **captivating** return to the spotlight after a decade-long **hiatus** from touring. As part of NPR's Black Music Month celebration honoring BET's legacy, the pair brought a set that felt both intimate and expansive. They opened with "Big Ben," a track that pays **homage** to their London origins, Stewart's poetic spoken word weaving through Ambrosius's floating **soprano**. Then came "Butterflies," a song Ambrosius co-wrote that became a signature hit for Michael Jackson. In the Tiny Desk's close quarters, her voice fluttered with a delicate power it was **mesmerizing**. But the duo's chemistry truly sparkled between songs. When they launched into the sensual slow jams "Say Yes" and "Getting Late," they couldn't help but crack up. "Is it too early for this?" they joked, their laughter filling the room. The audience, however, was all in singing along, swaying, and feeding off the palpable joy. That sisterhood, forged since their youth in London and deepened in Philadelphia's rich music scene, was the heartbeat of the performance. Stewart's grounded, rhythmic poetry balanced Ambrosius's **ethereal** runs, creating a sound that's both classic and fresh. They closed with "Floetic," their debut single, a full-circle moment that transported listeners back to the early 2000s when they first charmed the R&B world. It was a reminder that some bonds and some voices only get richer with time. For 20 minutes, the Tiny Desk became a sanctuary of soul, laughter, and the kind of genuine friendship that makes you believe in the power of music to bring people together.

Word Treasure

hiatus -- A break or pause from an activity; Floetry had a decade-long break from touring.

captivating -- So interesting or beautiful that it holds your attention completely.

homage -- Something done to show respect or honor, like their song that honored London.

soprano -- The highest singing voice for a woman, known for clear, high notes.

mesmerizing -- So amazing or fascinating that you can't look away or stop listening.

ethereal -- Light, delicate, and almost heavenly, often used to describe a voice.

Background you need

NPR's Tiny Desk Concert series, where artists perform behind a cluttered desk in National Public Radio's office, has become famous for intimate, stripped-down sets that reveal raw vocal and instrumental talent.

Black Music Month is celebrated every June in the United States, and BET (Black Entertainment Television, launched in 1980) has long championed Black artists across R&B, hip-hop, and soul.

Floetry broke out in the early 2000s with their album 'Floetic' and singles like 'Say Yes,' becoming part of the neo-soul movement linked to Philadelphia's vibrant music scene (the city that also nurtured artists like The Roots and Jill Scott).

Michael Jackson, one of the most influential pop stars in history, included 'Butterflies'--written by Ambrosius and Andre Harris--on his 2001 album 'Invincible,' giving the duo international songwriter recognition.

Break it down

LEAD: Reunion that feels like a homecoming after a decade-long touring hiatus

+ - **CONTEXT:** Part of NPR's Black Music Month celebration honoring BET's legacy

PERFORMANCE DETAIL: Opened with 'Big Ben,' spoken-word homage to London over floating soprano

+ - **HIGHLIGHT:** 'Butterflies,' the Michael Jackson hit, showcased a fluttering, mesmerizing voice

+ - **CHEMISTRY:** Playful banter during 'Say Yes' and 'Getting Late' -- laughter and audience participation

SISTERHOOD BOND: Forged in London, deepened in Philadelphia; grounded poetry meets ethereal runs

CLOSING: 'Floetic' brings a full-circle moment, transporting listeners to the early 2000s

REFLECTION: A 20-minute sanctuary of soul, laughter, and genuine friendship

Why it matters

For a middle-schooler, Floetry's reunion shows that meaningful creative partnerships can last even after long breaks, and that music can reconnect people and communities -- it's a reminder that true collaboration isn't about constant spotlight but about a bond you carry with you.

Test what you remember

1. Which song did Floetry open their Tiny Desk concert with?
 - (A) Butterflies
 - (B) Big Ben
 - (C) Say Yes
 - (D) Getting Late
2. Who made 'Butterflies' a famous hit after Marsha Ambrosius co-wrote it?
 - (A) Stevie Wonder
 - (B) Prince
 - (C) Michael Jackson
 - (D) Usher
3. How long had Floetry been on a touring hiatus before this reunion?
 - (A) Five years
 - (B) A decade
 - (C) Twenty years
 - (D) Since the early 2000s
4. What celebration was the Tiny Desk concert part of?
 - (A) NPR's anniversary
 - (B) Black Music Month honoring BET's legacy
 - (C) Women in Music week
 - (D) A 2000s R&B reunion special
5. Where did Natalie Stewart and Marsha Ambrosius's sisterhood originally develop?
 - (A) Atlanta and New York
 - (B) London and Philadelphia
 - (C) Los Angeles only
 - (D) Detroit
6. Which song closed their set and was described as a 'full-circle moment'?
 - (A) Floetic
 - (B) Butterflies
 - (C) Big Ben
 - (D) Say Yes

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

- 1. Positive / Nostalgic:** The concert gives longtime fans a joyful, nostalgic experience and reintroduces a uniquely genuine R&B sound to a new generation, celebrating an enduring musical partnership.
- 2. Negative / Skeptical:** Some might view reunion performances as commercial moves rather than heartfelt returns, though the duo's playful chemistry suggested their connection was real, not manufactured.
- 3. Neutral / Analytical:** The Tiny Desk format strips away glossy production, highlighting raw artistry, and the reunion fits a broader cultural wave of 2000s-era R&B nostalgia that has also brought other acts back into view.
- 4. Forward-looking:** A successful Tiny Desk appearance could pave the way for new Floetry music or a tour, possibly inspiring other influential duos from that era to reconnect with audiences in a similar way.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):